

An Orthodox Perspective on the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification

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Abstract

In 1999, the Roman Catholic Church and the Lutheran World Federation signed the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification, one of the main points at issue at the time of the 16th-century Reformation. This article seeks to offer an Orthodox perspective on the Joint Declaration, through presenting an “Orthodox” approach to the doctrine of justification as the doctrine is set out in the text of the Joint Declaration. The article then discusses how this approach is reflected in the three international and regional dialogues between the Orthodox Church and the churches of the Reformation that took place almost simultaneously with the dialogue leading to the Lutheran–Catholic Joint Declaration.

Keywords

Justification, sanctification, Lutheran–Orthodox dialogue, Orthodoxy

The doctrine of justification by grace through faith is a symbolic issue for the conflict that separated Catholics and Lutherans at the time of the Reformation. Today, as a result of the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification, which in 2019 marks its 20th anniversary, it is often held up as the issue that could contribute to the possible

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reunification of the Western Church. The real breakthrough, however, in the Joint Declaration rests not primarily in its content, even though it was carefully prepared through the dialogues that preceded it, which were taken into account and built upon by the declaration. The real breakthrough is in its official and joint endorsement by the respective churches, as Cardinal Walter Kasper has noted: “The crucial thing is that through the *Joint Declaration* the Churches themselves, rather than just theologians or even groups of theologians, have reached a consensus or convergence.”¹

With the declaration, the Roman Catholic Church and the Lutheran churches belonging to the Lutheran World Federation (LWF) publicly and bindingly stated that a consensus on basic truths of the doctrine of justification now exists between them. They also stated that, through this consensus, the teaching of the Lutheran churches presented in the Joint Declaration does not fall within the condemnations of the Council of Trent and that the condemnations of the Lutheran confessions regarding justification do not apply to the teaching of the Roman Catholic Church presented in the declaration.

It was also important that a substantive dialogue on justification took place between Lutherans and Catholics, because among the churches of the Reformation, it has been the Lutherans who have given most weight to the primacy of this doctrine, which they consider to be *articulus stantis* of the global construction of the Christian faith. If we are able today to acknowledge that the problem of justification is no longer a point of divergence in faith, even if it remains a sensitive point, there is a shift in the question that is now posed and which we could formulate thus: What is the potential of this declaration for the future?

Before offering several responses to this thorny question, I would first like to take a look at the Joint Declaration from the outside, from the perspective of a third-party partner in a joint debate. To do so, I will first present the “Orthodox” approach to the doctrine of justification as the doctrine is set out in the text of the Joint Declaration. I will then examine how this approach is reflected in the three international and regional dialogues between the Orthodox Church and the churches of the Reformation that took place almost simultaneously with the dialogues leading to the Lutheran–Catholic Joint Declaration. I am not aware that this question has been the subject of a direct discussion between the Orthodox and Catholic churches. Moreover, the Orthodox Church has never in its own history made the relationship between grace and works a soteriological question.

¹ Walter Kasper, “The Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification: A Roman Catholic Perspective,” in *Justification and the Future of the Ecumenical Movement: The Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification*, ed. William G. Rusch (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 2003), 17.

The Orthodox Approach to the Doctrine of Justification as Expressed in the Joint Declaration

Something that becomes clear when one turns to the theological debates that have beset the West throughout history, namely the Pelagian crisis of the late fourth and early fifth centuries or the Protestant Reformation of the 16th century, is that, from the outset, Eastern Christianity has displayed a certain lack of interest in soteriology expressed in terms of justification.

This lack of interest can be explained by Eastern Christianity espousing a different theological anthropology to that of most Western Christians – Catholics and Protestants – especially in the way it conceives human nature or the human condition after the fall. The way in which we understand these consequences depends, on the one hand, on our conception of soteriology, or our way of understanding the salvation offered to us in the person of the God-Man, Jesus Christ, that is to say, the meaning of salvation; and on the other, how we receive the salvation that is offered to us in Christ. The framework of these two different soteriological conceptions also reveal two different ways of understanding and defining the theological notions in which they are expressed, namely: sin, faith, and salvation.

The three Christian traditions – Lutheran, Catholic, and Orthodox – share a common response to the question “What is wrong with humanity?” They agree that, based on biblical accounts and our common experience, humanity lives outside of communion with God and that this lack of communion prevents the human being from being fully human. This state of separation from God is commonly called “sin.”

There are, however, important differences in how these three Christian traditions understand the way in which we live in this state and how it affects our human condition. In other words, there are different theologies of “original sin.” I shall not expand on this further except to say that the Joint Declaration in some senses sidesteps the question of original sin, possibly because of the intense debates that still exist within or between different confessions. As far as Orthodox theology is concerned, even if it shares an understanding of the dark sides of the human condition after the fall, it has never adhered to the notion of inherited original sin, the idea that humanity shares the guilt of the sin of Adam.

Although Orthodox anthropology has consistently recognized the effects of “sin of the origins” in terms of mortality, corruption, and the difficulty in maintaining an unbreakable communion with God, it has never accepted the idea that all humankind inherits the sin of Adam.

We inherit the same mortal and corrupt nature, but we do not inherit the guilt of original sin that has corrupted our nature and human condition. This anthropological position can be seen in the understanding of baptism and the sacramental practice that accompanies it. Of course, the Orthodox Church recognizes the importance of baptism for the remission of personal sin, but this is neither the primary nor the sole reason for baptism. The full meaning of baptism is the incorporation of the person being baptized into the body of Christ by the seal of the Holy Spirit. Therefore, the person baptized, even if a child, is fully incorporated into the sacramental and spiritual life of the church, and baptized children are thus full members of the church.

The question of original sin, or of what was lost by humanity in the fall, is related to the question of what God offered humanity in the act of creation and what has been preserved by humanity in its condition after the fall. At the heart of Orthodox anthropology is the concept of the *imago Dei*, and at the heart of this concept is the understanding of free will. Of course, Eastern Christianity recognizes that humanity has lost an element of its freedom in its submission to “passions,” understood as spiritual and physical needs and desires that impede human will, something to which ascetic writings testify in abundance. Nevertheless, although it is recognized that it is difficult to exercise one’s freedom in a consistent manner, Orthodox theology has been more or less unanimous since the first centuries in asserting the fundamental freedom of humanity to do good or to do evil, to turn to God or to turn away from God. As far as the classical Western position is concerned, it is summarized in the very title of section 4. 1. of the Joint Declaration: “Human Powerlessness and Sin in Relation to Justification.”

Thus, paragraph 21 states that, “According to Lutheran teaching, human beings are incapable of cooperating in their salvation, because as sinners they actively oppose God and his saving action.”² It is possible to discern in the preceding paragraph, which expresses the Catholic position, a more positive evaluation of the human response to God. But this position also opposes the role of human will by interpreting this human response as essentially divine and not human: “When Catholics say that persons ‘cooperate’ in preparing for and accepting justification by consenting to God’s justifying action, they see such personal consent as itself an effect of grace, not as an action arising from innate human abilities.” Catholics and Lutherans together affirm in the Joint Declaration that the human person as a sinner is “incapable of turning by themselves to God to seek deliverance” (§ 19).

² “Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification by the Lutheran World Federation and the Catholic Church,” <https://www.lutheranworld.org/jddj>.

There is not the space here to discuss all the details of the ways in which Western Christianity has attempted to answer these questions by relying on the concept of prevenient grace on the one hand, and the doctrine of predestination on the other. But this does not seem indispensable since the Joint Declaration states that “All people are called by God to salvation in Christ” (section 3, § 16).

Orthodox anthropology, based on the Christology of the Sixth Ecumenical Council held in Constantinople in 680 to 681, articulated a positive theological anthropology of the human condition by distinguishing between the “natural” human will, which is an innate characteristic of human nature, and the “gnomic” will. While in the first, the natural will of the human being is oriented toward God and continues to exist and act as such even after the fall, the gnomic will refers to a particular behaviour, a personal disposition, or an approach that expresses the natural will that is peculiar to fallen beings and is characterized by holding opinions and thinking things through in ways that do not allow for perceiving that which is Good clearly.³

Maximos the Confessor, the Byzantine theologian of the seventh century whose Christological teaching forms the foundation for the decisions of the Sixth Ecumenical Council, insisted that self-determination (literally, self-determined action) is a component of human nature but does not represent a purpose in itself. Our free natural will has been directed to God since the creation of human beings, precisely because humanity is created by God and in his image.

So, to answer the soteriological question of knowing “what is wrong with humanity in its fallen state,” Orthodox theological anthropology would not say, as Western theology does, that humanity is no longer naturally turned toward God, but that we have broken communion with God and that our spiritual vision has thus “darkened,” so that we no longer clearly recognize the direction of our natural orientation, and that as a result we do not always take this path to restore our communion with God. The Greek word used to signify sin is illuminating here. *Hamartia* means “miss the target.” Despite being orientated toward God, we “miss the target” because not only is our spiritual vision distorted, but we fail to understand ourselves. Thus we often act in an inauthentic and unfree manner, in other words, in one dominated by desires and passions.

After examining what is wrong with humankind after the fall, we should now consider the principal soteriological response of the Joint Declaration to the question “What will make humanity righteous?” The answer could be summed up in the well-known adage of St Gregory of Nazianzus: “What has not been assumed [in Christ] has not

³ See my doctoral thesis: *La synergie entre la grâce divine et la volonté de l'homme*, “Théologies” collection (Paris: Cerf Patrimoines, 2018).

been healed.”⁴ The “justification” of the Joint Declaration is thus defined in terms of the healing of our human nature fully assumed in Jesus Christ apart from sin, which according to Orthodox theology is not an integral part of human nature.

When it speaks of the incarnation of Christ, Orthodox theology recognizes two goals that can be identified: justification, on the one hand, and sanctification, on the other. Justification is understood as restoring nature or the human condition to its pre-fall state by returning it to its full potential, and sanctification is understood as the possibility of true union with God through participation. The first objective was made necessary by the fall and it remained at the centre of the Western soteriology of the cross. For Orthodox theology, the incarnation has always been part of God’s plan, since it was the means by which humanity could truly achieve salvation understood as *theosis*, deification or union with God. This idea is expressed in an extraordinary way in the response of Maximos the Confessor to the 60th question of Thalassios:

This is the mystery which circumscribes all the ages, and which reveals the grand plan of God, a super-infinite plan infinitely pre-existing the ages an infinite number of times. The essential Word of God became a messenger of this plan when He became man, and, if I might rightly say so, revealed Himself as the innermost depth of the Father’s goodness while also displaying in Himself the very goal for which creatures manifestly received the beginning of their existence.⁵

This ontological approach to our salvation in Christ has at least two important implications for the Joint Declaration on Justification. First, justification, as we have seen, is not understood in a legal but in an existential sense. This makes it possible to say that the initiative and the action of God regarding the creation of humanity in his image, and his incarnation, his cross, and his resurrection have a universal significance for humanity and a cosmic importance for the whole of creation. Will human beings take advantage of this salvation and restoration offered in Christ? It depends on how they exercise their human freedom by either responding or not responding to the union with God offered to them in Christ by the gift of the Holy Spirit. In this spirit, Maximos the Confessor noted that salvation belongs to all, but is available only to those who receive it freely and voluntarily.⁶

It must be emphasized, however, that Orthodox soteriology does not equate salvation with justification alone, especially justification conceived in a limited legal way, as “imputed righteousness.” Orthodoxy conceives justification in a broad sense, and salvation in an even broader sense, as a relation and an organic process, and not as an event or

⁴ St Gregory of Nazianzus, Letter 101, *Sources Chrétiennes* 208, 50; *Patrologia Graeca* 37, 181C–184A.

⁵ St. Maximos the Confessor, *On Difficulties in Sacred Scripture: The Responses to Thalassios*, trans. Maximos Constas (Washington, DC: Catholic University Press of America, 2018).

⁶ Vidovic, *Synergie*, 221.

a static state of being. Salvation is not the return of the “paradise lost.” Nor is it merely the healing of the fallen human condition, but rather the spiritual development toward the maturity of the human being realized “according to the measure of Christ’s gift” (Eph. 4:7). To grow in this divine likeness, to live an ever more authentic human existence, signifies communion and union with God. This doctrine of deification is a direct consequence of the ontological soteriology of incarnation, as expressed by St Athanasius of Alexandria: “He [the Logos] became human that we might become divine.”⁷ Deification is thus not only a “goal” of salvation, it *is* salvation in its essence and fulfilment.

Dialogues between Orthodox and Lutherans on Justification

The theological dialogue between the Orthodox Church and the churches of the Reformation of the 20th century relate in a particular way to what has been outlined above. Nevertheless, the dialogue must be considered in the broader context of the relationship between these two traditions. The first contacts between them began in the century of the Reformation, first through the initiative of Philipp Melanchthon who sent the *Confessio Augustana* translated into Greek to Constantinople, and then through the correspondence between the Lutheran theologians of Tübingen and the Ecumenical Patriarch Jeremiah II (1573–1581).⁸ The dialogues that followed were rather sporadic, and unfortunately marked by proselytism. Relations between the two church traditions improved in the 20th century, in particular through cooperation in the framework of the wider ecumenical movement.

Although the goals and objectives of these dialogues have not always been clearly stated and there are no clear methodological models that should or could be applied to each dialogue, the sharing of these experiences and analyzing the methods used could open new and fruitful approaches to future theological dialogues.⁹

⁷ Athanasius of Alexandria, “On the Incarnation of the Word 54,” *Patrologia Graeca* 25, 192B.

⁸ The three letters of Patriarch Jeremiah II of Constantinople are available online: <http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/jeremiah.aspx>.

⁹ On these dialogues see the works of Risto Saarinen: *Faith and Holiness: Lutheran–Orthodox Dialogue 1959–1994* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1997); “The Lutheran–Orthodox Joint Commission: Our Work 1994–2003,” in *Cracks in the Walls*, ed. E. M. Wiberg (Frankfurt: Peter Lang, 2005), 121–29; “The Lutheran–Orthodox Joint Commission,” <https://blogs.helsinki.fi/ristosaarinen/lutheran-orthodox-dialogue>; “The Lutheran–Orthodox Relationships and the Future of Ecumenism,” in *Lutheranism: Legacy and Future*, ed. H. Roggelin (West Conshohocken: Infinity Publishing, 2012), 375–95; “Le dialogue luthérien-orthodoxe de 2004 à 2014,” *Istina* 59 (2014), 367–86. I also recommend visiting Saarinen’s website, where historical and bibliographic documentation is regularly updated: <http://blogs.helsinki.fi/ristosaarinen>. One may also add the excellent works of two Orthodox theologians: C. D. Pricop, *From Espoo to Paphos: The Theological Dialogue of the Orthodox Churches with the Lutheran World Federation (1981–2008)* (Bucharest: Basilica Publishing House, 2013), and T. Meimaris “Thirty Years of the International Theological Dialogue between Orthodox and Lutherans (1981–2011): Evaluation and Prospects,” *Nicolaus: Rivista di Teologia ecumenico-patristica* (2013), 159–86.

As early as 1959, the Evangelical Church of Germany (EKD), which groups German Lutheran, Reformed, and United regional churches, began a dialogue with the Moscow Patriarchate.¹⁰ The EKD has also maintained a permanent dialogue with the Ecumenical Patriarchate since 1969,¹¹ and with the Romanian Orthodox Church since 1979.¹² The Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland began a dialogue with the Russian Orthodox Church in 1970,¹³ while the Joint International Commission for the Theological Dialogue between the Orthodox Church and the Lutheran World Federation began its work in 1981.¹⁴

The Joint International Commission for the Theological Dialogue between the Orthodox Church and the Lutheran World Federation

The Joint International Commission, consisting of members appointed by the LWF on the one hand and the Autocephalous Orthodox Churches on the other, met more or less concurrently with the Lutheran–Catholic Commission which worked on the drafting of the Declaration on Justification, namely between 1995 and 1998, and issued two significant statements at the conclusion of the dialogues. The first statement is entitled “Understanding of Salvation in the Light of the Ecumenical Councils,” and was published after the eighth plenary session of the Joint Commission which met in 1995 in Limassol, Cyprus.¹⁵ The second is entitled “Salvation: Grace, Justification and Synergy,” and was published at the end of the ninth session of the commission, which met three years later in Sigtuna in Sweden in 1998.¹⁶

Even though these two documents are much shorter than the Joint Declaration on Justification, they express the concept of justification in a very interesting way while preserving the notions and concepts specific to each of the ecclesial traditions, namely, the “Synergy” peculiar to the Orthodox tradition and the “*sola fide*” of the Lutheran tradition. The paragraphs that are particularly interesting are numbers 7 to 9 of the 1995 statement:

¹⁰ See Saarinen, *Faith and Holiness*, 84–127; Kirchenamt der EKD, ed., *Hinbören und binseben: Beziehungen zwischen der Russischen Orthodoxen Kirche und der Evangelischen Kirche in Deutschland* (Leipzig: Evangelische Verlagsanstalt, 2003).

¹¹ See Saarinen, *Faith and Holiness*, 128–38.

¹² Ibid., 139–54.

¹³ See ibid., 20–83; Juha Pihkala, ed., *Faith and Love: Shared Doctrine Reached on the Basis of the Dialogues of the Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland and the Russian Orthodox Church* (Helsinki: Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland, 2017).

¹⁴ See <https://www.lutheranworld.org/content/resource-agreed-lutheran-orthodox-statements-1985-2011>.

¹⁵ “Understanding of Salvation in the Light of the Ecumenical Councils,” https://www.lutheranworld.org/sites/default/files/1995-Lutheran_Orthodox_Dialogue-EN.pdf.

¹⁶ “Salvation: Grace, Justification and Synergy,” https://www.lutheranworld.org/sites/default/files/1998-Lutheran_Orthodox_Dialogue-EN.pdf.

7. In the New Testament the one mystery of salvation is expressed in different but essentially complementary terms such as sanctification, justification, redemption, adoption, liberation, glorification etc. In interpreting the apostolic teaching on salvation, our two ecclesiastical traditions developed different emphases.

8. For the Orthodox Church, salvation is a gratuitous gift of God offered in Jesus Christ to all human beings (1 Tim. 2:4; Jn. 3:17), which they must both freely choose (Rev. 3:20) and work for (1 Cor. 3:13, 15:58; Phil. 2:12). According to St. Paul, this is synergia (1 Cor. 3:9; 2 Cor. 6:1). Once this gift of the divine grace is accepted by faith, Christ truly becomes the doctor of the souls and bodies of the faithful in the Holy Spirit, through the Word of God and the mysteries of the Church. He purifies their hearts (Ps. 50/51:10, Acts 15:9) and constantly renews their minds (Rom. 12:2; 2 Cor. 4:16), leading them from illumination/justification (2 Cor. 4:6) manifested by prayer in the heart (Rom. 8:26; Eph. 5:19, 6:18; Col. 3:16) and keeping of the commandments (1 Jn. 3:22), to glorification (Jn. 17:22; 1 Cor. 12:26). The Orthodox Church does not hold that humanity inherited the guilt of the sin of Adam and Eve and is therefore worthy of eternal damnation, or that God chose from those thus guilty certain ones only to be saved without personal merit, or that Christ died on the Cross only for them, or that Christ loves only those sinners who are destined for heaven, or that God had to be reconciled to humanity by Christ's crucifixion.¹⁷

In this section we find a synthesis of what was said earlier about Orthodox soteriology and its positive and negative understanding of justification. The paragraph that follows presents the Lutheran position:

9. Lutherans understand the saving work which God accomplishes in Christ through the Holy Spirit primarily through the concept of "justification." For Lutherans, justification is God's gracious declaration of the forgiveness of sins for the sake of Jesus Christ, crucified and risen, and at the same time the free gift of new life in him. Through the liturgical life, preaching, and sacraments of the Church, the Holy Spirit enables us to have faith in the gospel – that is, in God's gracious promise of forgiveness and new life. This promise is received by faith alone (*sola fide*); this means that salvation is by Christ alone, and not by any human works or merits. In faith Christians entrust themselves entirely to God's grace in Christ for salvation. In this way they enter a new relationship with God, as St. Paul says: "since we are justified by faith we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (Rom. 5:1). Justification is a real participation in Christ, true God and true human being. In the Church, the believer by faith participates in Christ and all his gifts, and so has a share in the divine life. The presence of Christ in faith genuinely effects the righteousness of Christ in us, and leads believers to the sanctification of their lives. In this way, believers work out their salvation in fear and trembling, trusting that God in Christ is at work in them, both to will and to work for his good pleasure (Phil. 2:12-13).¹⁸

After presenting the approaches of the two traditions, the concluding paragraph notes that Lutherans and Orthodox "still need to explore further their different concepts of

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Ibid.

salvation as purification, illumination, and glorification, with the use of *synergia*, which is the Orthodox teaching and tradition and as justification and sanctification, with the use of *sola fide*, which is the Lutheran teaching and tradition.”¹⁹

In response to this request, the ninth plenary meeting of the Joint Commission in Sigtuna adopted the following statement:

9. Both Lutherans and Orthodox teach that divine grace operates universally and that God freely grants grace to all human beings. God’s saving grace does not operate by necessity or in an irresistible manner, since human beings can reject it. Regarding the way in which salvation is appropriated by the believers, Lutherans, by teaching that justification and salvation are by grace alone through faith (*sola gratia, sola fide*), stress the absolute priority of divine grace in salvation. When they speak about saving faith they do not think of the dead faith which even the demons have (cf. James 2:19), but the faith which Abraham showed and which was reckoned to him as righteousness (cf. Gen. 15:6, Rom. 4:3,9). The Orthodox also affirm the absolute priority of divine grace. They underline that it is God’s grace which enables our human will to conform to the divine will (cf. Phil 2:13) in the steps of Jesus praying, “not as I will but as You will” (Matt. 26:39), so that we may work out our salvation in fear and trembling (cf. Phil. 2:12). This is what the Orthodox mean by “synergy” (working together) of divine grace and the human will of the believer in the appropriation of the divine life in Christ. The understanding of synergy in salvation is helped by the fact that the human will in the one person of Christ was not abolished when the human nature was united in Him with the divine nature, according to the Christological decisions of the Ecumenical Councils. While Lutherans do not use the concept of synergy, they recognize the personal responsibility of the human being in the acceptance or refusal of divine grace through faith, and in the growth of faith and obedience to God. Lutherans and Orthodox both understand good works as the fruits and manifestations of the believer’s faith and not as a means of salvation.²⁰

The Sigtuna document is perhaps the most important text of the whole global dialogue since the beginnings of the dialogue in 1981. Thus, as Risto Saarinen has noted:

The Orthodox side presents the doctrine of theosis in such a manner that the Lutherans were able to understand it as a biblical view. On the other hand, Lutherans introduced the concept of sanctification, or the insight concerning the presence of Christ in faith, from their tradition and used it to argue that the Protestant doctrine of justification is not completely alien to the idea of participation in divine life. The Sigtuna text employs biblical language and avoids stating anything on the extremely difficult issue of whether this participation exclusively consists of God’s “energies”, as the Palamitic version of Orthodox mysticism has claimed.²¹

This is also a point worthy of development in the context of the debate about justification.

¹⁹ Ibid.

²⁰ “Salvation: Grace, Justification and Synergy.”

²¹ Risto Saarinen, “The Lutheran-Orthodox Joint Commission,” *Reseptio* 09:1 (2019), 24–25; https://evl.fi/documents/1327140/39531482/Reseptio1_2009.pdf.

This dialogue has further demonstrated that these two ecclesial traditions have much more in common than might have been supposed before these encounters. However, it left open many questions related to the topics discussed. The reception of the dialogue also remains an open question. It is disappointing that the documents that were presented at these meetings and which accompanied them have still not been published. In the meantime, we are indebted to Professor Risto Saarinen of the University of Helsinki, in Finland, for his work in publishing all the joint statements, which remains the only global publication of this dialogue so far.²²

Dialogues between the Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland and the Russian Orthodox Church

The Russo-Finnish dialogue, which began in 1970 and ended in 2014, became well known thanks to the 1977 Kiev Declaration, entitled “Salvation as Justification and Deification.” What made this statement important was the fact that Lutherans were able to identify positively with the Eastern doctrine of deification. Similar statements were also made in subsequent dialogues. It is important to note that as far as research was concerned, deification at that time was also a fairly popular theme in Protestant theology.²³

In short, the dialogue demonstrated the existence of a passage between two worlds of thought, hitherto held irreconcilable: one built on the basis of the concept of justification, the other on the idea of deification. Nevertheless, it also faced a problem that proved to be the crucial point for the future Lutheran–Orthodox dialogue, namely the notion of “synergy,” about which the dialogue was never able to formulate a clear consensus. For Lutheranism, deification is admissible as long as it is integrated into the sphere of faith. For Orthodoxy, faith is only the starting point of the path to deification. This difficulty of unifying the Lutheran and Orthodox points of view is expressed in point seven of the Kiev joint statement:

Grace never does violence to a man’s personal will, but exerts its influence through it and with it. Everyone has the opportunity to refuse consent to God’s will or, by the help of the Holy Spirit, to consent to it. Furthermore, the opinion of the Orthodox part is that what has been said above presupposes cooperation between God’s saving grace and man, i.e. freedom of will.²⁴

²² <https://blogs.helsinki.fi/ristosaarinen/lutheran-orthodox-dialogue>.

²³ See R. Saarinen, *Faith and Holiness*, 38–54; V.-M. Kärkkäinen, *One with God: Salvation as Deification and Justification* (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 2004); M. Christensen et al., *Partakers of the Divine Nature* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Baker Academic, 2007).

²⁴ “Summary of the theme ‘Salvation as justification and deification’, at the theological conversations between the Evangelical Lutheran Church of Finland and the Russian Orthodox Church in the centre of the Exarchate of the Ukraine in Kiev during April 12th–16th, 1977,” in Pihkala, ed., *Faith and Love*, 76–77.

What prevents Lutheranism from accepting the Orthodox concept of self-determination is the idea that this self-determination includes responsibility – and therefore human merit – in the reception of one's own salvation. Nevertheless, as is suggested by a remark by Lutheran Professor Tuomo Mannermaa, who sought to push Lutheran theology as far as possible in the direction of Orthodox theology: "From a Lutheran perspective, any movement of human will toward grace is not equally decisive in relation to salvation. In this perspective, one can conceive of a self-determination of the will in all the movements that follow the initial moment of conversion . . . after the new birth, that is, after baptism, as taught by the Book of Concord, human will is liberated. This is key to all our future discussions."²⁵

In the discussions in Mikkeli in 1986, the Lutheran theologian Juha Pihkala stated with great clarity: "When God engenders us to new life, our free will is liberated. Following that, we can cooperate with God in a very real way. In this sense, the Lutheran Church also teaches synergy and holds it for necessary. This is the struggle of faith, to which we are all called. However, when a human being is called to be born to the new life, it is God who operates; it is he who brings it about. God liberates our will. At this point, we cannot talk about synergism. But after that, we need to talk about synergy."²⁶

Confronted by accusations in the Lutheran world that the doctrine of Luther had been sacrificed to a compromise with synergism, Pihkala made a distinction between the synergism rejected by the Lutheran tradition and the Orthodox *synergai*: "The concept of the seventh thesis [of Kiev] indicates that there is no question of the cooperation that the Lutheran confession rejects under the name of synergism. It is a question of the cooperation between the will of the human being who has been justified and the divine will. From an Orthodox point of view, the important point is to remove all quietism: a human being who is saved is not in Lutheranism a passive 'object,' but an active subject."²⁷

The Russian-Finnish dialogue takes up the ideas of the progress of salvation in its 2005 declaration, which concerned theological anthropology, and especially human freedom. The statement does not mention *theosis*, but evokes the liberation of sin in stronger terms than do most Lutheran texts:

²⁵ Antoine Lévy, o.p., "Synergisme ou synergie? Liberté et grâce dans le dialogue entre luthériens finlandais et orthodoxes russes," *Istina* 53 (2008), 352, quoting the minutes of the Kiev dialogue (1997).

²⁶ Minutes of the Mikkeli dialogue (1986), quoted in *ibid.*, 353.

²⁷ "Have Lutherans swallowed synergism?" Preparatory seminar for the Turku meeting (1981), 2, quoted in *ibid.*, 353.

A human who turns to Christ in faith is freed from the power of evil by the work of the Holy Spirit in the Church, and this individual's will is made whole and compliant to God's will.

I.10. God's grace in Christ releases a human from slavery to the law and from bondage to sin. The Holy Spirit awakens the liberated human to want as well as to do what is good (John 8:32, Rom. 6:18, Rom. 8:2, Gal. 5:1). This freedom given by God as a gift includes as a first fruit an experience of the wholeness into which humankind has been created but which is only fully realized in eternity (Rom. 8:23). Gospel accounts of healing foreshadow final and holistic salvation.²⁸

Without going into the details of the theological content of the theses mutually adopted on the "Christian understanding of being a human," we can observe that in general they express an anthropological vision in which both the freedom of the human being in creation and their limited will after the fall are expressed in a way that avoids exacerbating certain expressions of both traditions (in Lutheranism, the perversion and incapacity of human will after the fall, in Orthodoxy the capacity of the human will even after the fall). Thus, a remarkable convergence on one of the most difficult doctrinal issues between the Lutheran and Orthodox traditions was reached in the theses set out in Turku in 2005.

Dialogue between the Romanian Orthodox Church and the Evangelical Church in Germany

Some consider this dialogue as the most successful from a theological point of view.²⁹ Certainly, it is the dialogue that has been the subject of the greatest number of studies and secondary research work.³⁰ In the context of the subject that we are dealing with here, the most recent meeting in 2013 between the EKD and the Romanian Orthodox, whose final document is named "Holiness and Sanctification" is a good example. Risto Saarinen notes: "Compared with the Finnish–Russian text of 2005 . . . the EKD–Romanian text in my view can avoid misunderstandings and bring the theological resources of both churches into an important convergence."³¹ Thus paragraph eight of the statement reads:

²⁸ "Turku 2005: Summary: The Christian View on Human Being in Today's Europe: Salvation, Faith and Modern Social Realities," in Pihkala, ed., *Faith and Love*, 115–16.

²⁹ See Saarinen, *Faith and Holiness*, 154.

³⁰ See Constantin Patuleanu, *Die Begegnung der rumänischen Orthodoxie mit dem Protestantismus* (Hamburg: Kovač, 2000), and Nicolae Manole, *Ekklesiologische Perspektiven im Dialog zwischen den orthodoxen und reformatorischen Kirchen* (Münster: Lit-Verlag, 2005).

³¹ Risto Saarinen, "Lutheran–Orthodox Dialogue from 2004 to 2015," 10; <https://blogs.helsinki.fi/ristosaarinen/files/2017/08/luth-orth-until2015-1.pdf>.

In this process of sanctification the believer responds to the call of God to holiness, as expressed in Lev. 19:2, and to the exhortation of Christ, to be perfect or holy (Matt. 5:48). The whole life of the believer thus becomes a spiritual sacrifice, a rational worship (*logike latreia*) and it enters a communion with God also within this world. ... In this process of sanctification, which is donated to the believer and in which he also participates as subject, the believer experiences a growth of his already real communion with Christ. Thus the rational worship in the world is equipped with a new quality in the sense of Phil 3:12 (*epektasis*) (§ 8).³²

Concluding Remarks

Despite the diversity of their contexts, expressions, and approaches, all of these dialogues seem to have arrived at similar conclusions. In saying this, we need to realize that a surprising theological proximity can be seen in the areas that, given the polemical controversy and the lack of communication between the branches of the church that have lasted for centuries, might not necessarily be expected. While doctrinal agreements have not been concluded, such agreements were not envisaged as immediate objectives of the dialogues. Nevertheless, convergence has developed between the different doctrinal traditions, particularly in the field of soteriology.

What emerges as especially interesting in this brief review of the dialogues concerned is not so much the points of convergence but rather the different emphases that have been set by each tradition. Thus,

1. The concept of *theosis*, so important to the Orthodox Church, is not used in the theology of Reformation churches, although it is powerfully expressed in the Christmas carols of the Protestant churches. On the other hand, the term “justification,” so important for Reformation theology, is less rooted in Orthodox worship, although all worship is marked by prayer for the forgiveness of sins and for the help of the grace of God.
2. Orthodox theology uses the concept of *theosis* for human beings, while the theology of the Reformation uses the concept of “justification” or “sanctification.”
3. The theology of justice relies mainly on the language of St Peter and the Apostle Paul, while the theology of *theosis* is based on Johannine terminology.

³² See Martin Schindehütte and Martin Illert, eds, *Die Apostolizität der Kirche. Heiligkeit und Heiligung. 12. und 13. Begegnung im bilateralen Theologischen Dialog zwischen der Rumänischen Orthodoxen Kirche und der EKD*, Beiheft zur Ökumenischen Rundschau 97 (Leipzig: Evangelische Verlagsanstalt, 2014); English translation in Risto Saarinen, “Lutheran–Orthodox Dialogue from 2004 to 2015,” <https://blogs.helsinki.fi/ristosaarinen/files/2017/08/luth-orth-until2015-1.pdf>.

4. Orthodox theology makes a clear distinction between *theosis* in a narrow sense, where God leads the Christian only after their death to perfection by communion with Christ, and *theosis* in a broader sense, which is the way of sanctification of the human being here on earth in the struggle against sin. In Lutheran and Protestant theology, the term “justification” generally refers to the whole salvific work of God in the baptized and righteous human being.
5. Orthodox theology considers the works of the Christian on the path of sanctification as a “synergy” of the believer with Christ. In the theology of the Reformation, this term is not customary, because the word “synergism” has a negative connotation.
6. The theology of the Reformation emphasizes the forensic nature of justice, while the Orthodox Church gives an account of the ontological nature of justice, manifested in renewal, without excluding its forensic dimension.

Future Perspectives

Based on these documents and 20 years after their publication, is it possible to arrive at a three-way consensus? In response to this question, I share the same position as Nicolas Kazarian, who has noted: “I am convinced that the introduction of Orthodoxy as a third party deepens not only the scope of the way we understand justification, but also the ability of the different documents to dialogue with each other, while respecting the theological differences of each of the Christian traditions.”³³

As was noted during the consultation in Pullach organized by the Conference of European Churches (CEC) on dialogues between Orthodox and other CEC member churches,³⁴ more attention should be paid to communicating the results of the dialogues at all levels of church life.³⁵ It was pointed out that “In discussion it became evident that even among ourselves we are not always fully aware of the ecclesiological self understanding of our dialogue partners. We realize that it is incumbent on us all in dialogues to begin to understand the other from his or her respective Church tradition.”³⁶

³³ Nicolas Kazarian, “Regard orthodoxe sur la Déclaration commune luthéro-catholique sur la doctrine de la justification,” *Unité des Chrétiens* 193 (2019), 24.

³⁴ “Consultation on Dialogues between Orthodox and other Member Churches of CEC, Pullach, Germany, 23–25 June 2008,” *Reseptio* 09:1 (2019), 10; https://evl.fi/documents/1327140/39531482/Reseptio1_2009.pdf.

³⁵ Kaisamari Hintikka and Viorel Ionita, “Preface,” *ibid.*, 9–11; https://evl.fi/documents/1327140/39531482/Reseptio1_2009.pdf.

³⁶ “Consultation on Dialogues between Orthodox and other Member Churches of CEC,” 10.

In conclusion, we should return to the work of the Finnish theologians, which found its way into the statements of the Lutheran–Orthodox dialogue, even if it was not picked up in the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification. Some traces of it are nevertheless perceptible, for example the passage in paragraph 26 of the declaration, which discusses participation in common life. Perhaps future research and meetings will pave the way for the next stage of bilateral and multilateral theological dialogue, namely that some of the differences in the soteriological approach may be seen more as the result of different perspectives rather than real substantive differences.

From an Orthodox point of view, it would be desirable to continue to move away from a compartmentalized methodology and from an anthropology and a legal and passive soteriology to adopt a holistic methodology explaining a more generous anthropology and an existential, relational, and synergistic soteriology. Neither should we abandon the doctrinal, sacramental, and spiritual approach that must remain the foundation of these dialogues, even though they are increasingly tending to turn to questions of ethics and society.

Most of the elements are already present, but soteriology needs to be integrated not only more ontologically with Christology, but also with spirituality and sacramental theology. Integrating dogmatic theology more closely with spirituality and sacramental theology would bring out the dimension of pneumatology, which remains rather weak in the Joint Declaration. For it must be noted that it was through the Holy Spirit that the Son of God became incarnate; it is through the Holy Spirit that Jesus Christ was raised from the dead; it is through the Holy Spirit that we are doubly initiated to the double salvific effects of the incarnation – restoration of our nature corrupted by baptism and the beginning of growth, *theosis*, to receiving the Holy Spirit through chrismation, and by the descent of the Holy Spirit during the epiclesis, and when we find ourselves united collectively with Christ, present in the eucharist.

The passage from theological ecumenism to practical ecumenism, and from there to spiritual ecumenism, represents the path that these significant statements need to take to be fully received by our respective churches. Full communion cannot be attained by convergence alone, but by conversion, which implies repentance, forgiveness, and renewal of the heart.